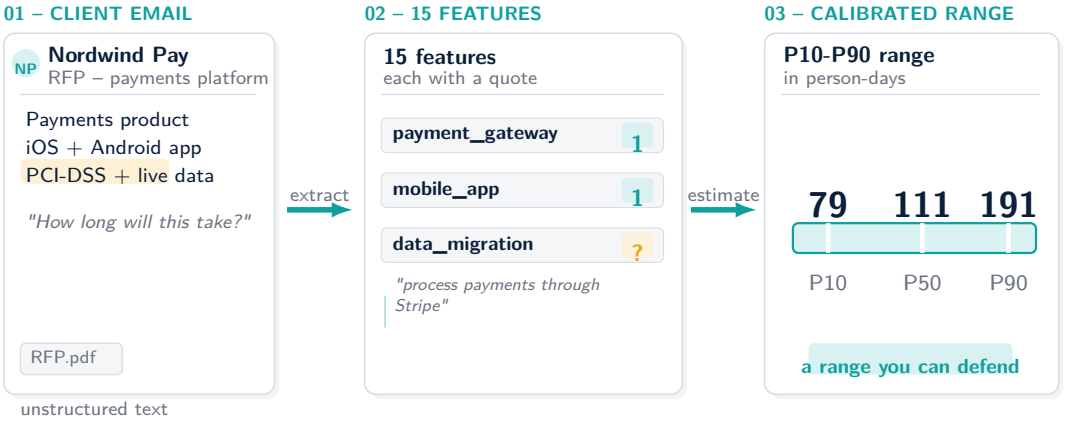
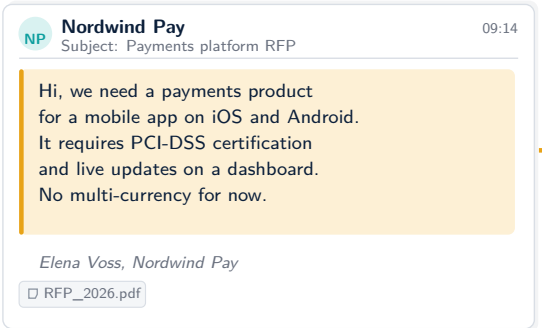
THE ESTIMATOR

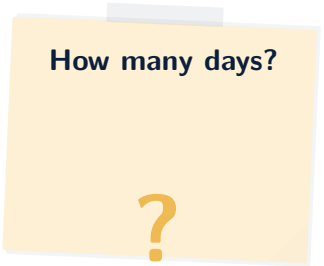
Built with AI. Trusted because it is tested.

Nguyen My Thong · AI Business Operations · Anduin



A client email. Two hours. Still a guess.





2 hours reading | 3 clarifying questions | still a guess

Confident. Consistent. Wrong.

LLM-only: 258 days MAE. Five runs, one answer. The error is calibration, not randomness.

LLM-only

258

days MAE
last 42 projects

The Estimator

19

days MAE
same 42 projects

no history | no calibration | no evidence | **missing info = guess**

Only one option survives an audit.

Speed vs audit: fastest loses the trail; the split keeps it.

A LLM end-to-end ✗

reads + estimates

- fast
- no audit
- no calibration

rejected

B LLM + rules ~

extract + rules

- auditable
- brittle
- no learning

trade-off

C LLM + math ✓

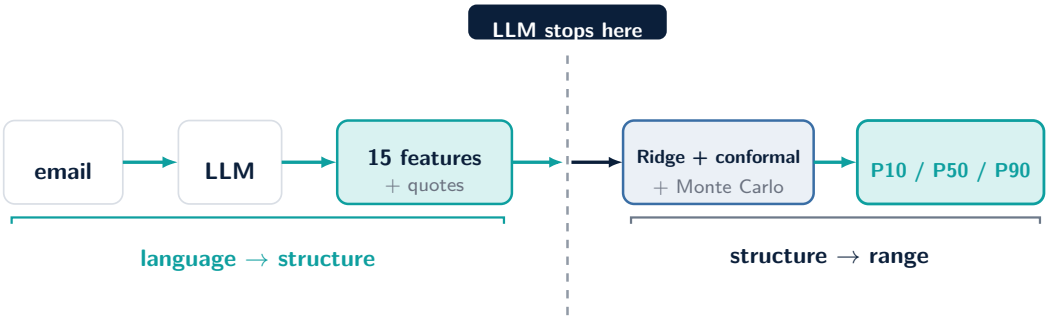
extract only → math

- auditable
- calibrated
- learns

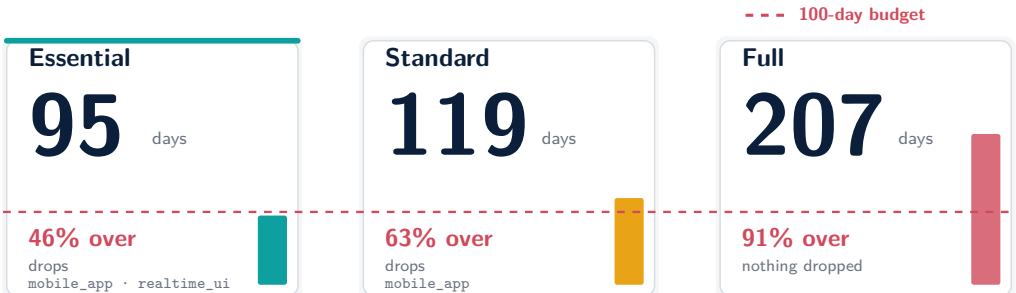
chosen

AI reads. Math decides.

Every field carries a quote; silence widens the range instead of guessing.



A budget turns the range into a decision.



Recommended **Essential** · renegotiate budget or timeline

Proof, including the ugly parts.

Walk-forward on 218 steps: half the team's error, 86.7% coverage, five negative results published.

17.36
MAE vs 32.93



86.7%
coverage 189/218



0.933
extraction F1



$0.20
for 240 emails



242 offline tests

31 decisions

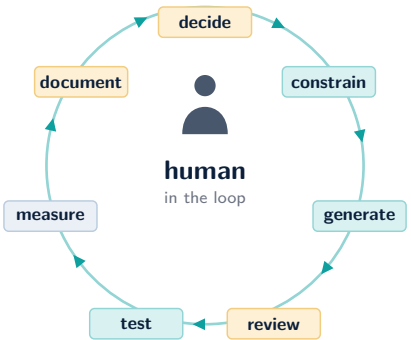
20.48 MAE end-to-end

AI wrote fast. I owned the loop.

The draft came from DeepSeek; the constraint, review, and measurement were mine.

AI

- DeepSeek
- code assistant
- eval scripts



Human

- decide
- review
- gatekeep

built
on a phone

Six checks before anything ships.

Fast vs trustworthy: six checks make someone else's diff defensible.

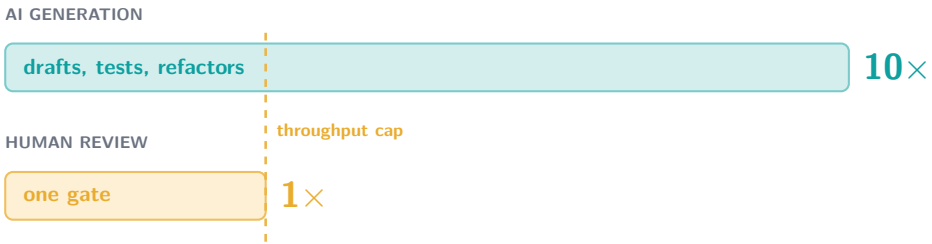
Review before merge

6 checks

- ☑ **Contract** — does it match the interface?
- ☑ **Failure modes** — empty, None, huge input?
- ☑ **Determinism** — same input → same output?
- ☑ **Evidence** — can I trace the number?
- ☑ **Tests** — fails when I break it?
- ☑ **Rollback** — can I revert in one commit?

Generation scales. Review does not.

Throughput vs capacity: the gate sets the speed, so I'd standardise it.




```
shipped = min(generation, review)
```

WHERE I INVEST INSTEAD OF PROMPTS

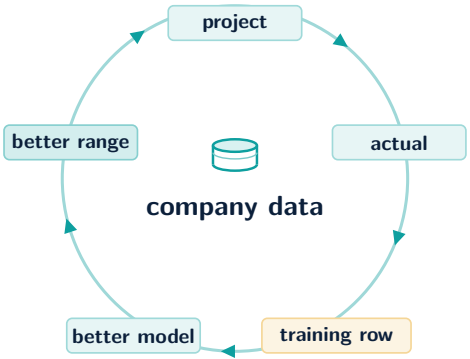
- shared eval set
- same six checks
- small diffs

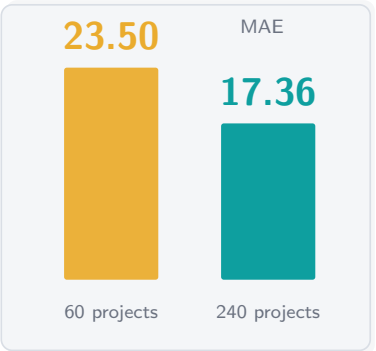
My first version was worse than doing nothing.



The moat is the company's own data.

Model vs data: every project is a training row: 60 → 240, MAE 23.50 → 17.36.

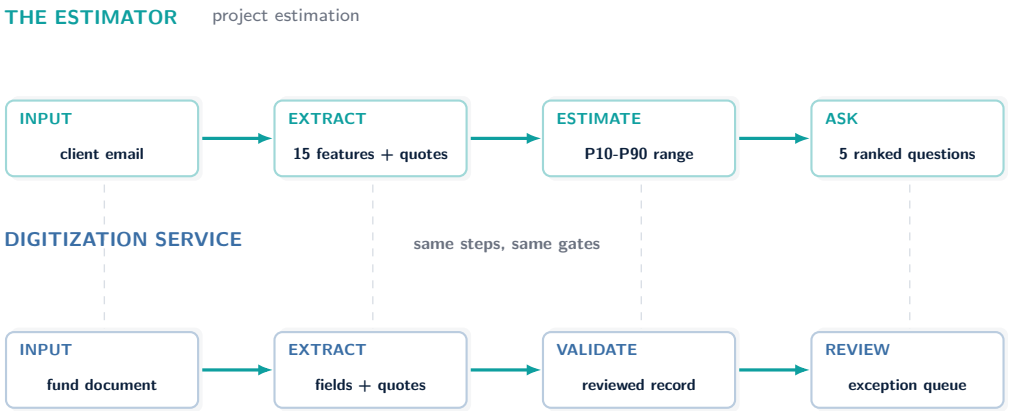




same model, more history

Digitization has the same shape.

Same steps: document in, fields with evidence, a human clears exceptions.



Shadow. Ship. Measure or kill.

Ambition vs proof: a baseline, one narrow tool, a gate at every step.

day 0 — day 14 — day 45 — day 90

01 · DAYS 1-14

Shadow

Time one workflow. Count rework. Inventory existing automations.

OUTPUT

Baseline minutes per document, error rate.

GATE

A number, not an opinion.

02 · DAYS 15-45

Ship one slice

One document type, end to end. Every field keeps its evidence.

OUTPUT

A tool the team opens daily; a human clears every record.

GATE

No unreviewed record leaves the queue.

03 · DAYS 46-90

Measure or kill

Re-run the week-2 baseline. Keep what beats it.

OUTPUT

Before/after numbers and a one-page playbook.

GATE

Beats baseline, or it stops.

I don’t use AI to skip thinking.

I use it to think faster. Then I test harder.

shipped
one container, one URL

tested
242 offline tests

honest
5 negative results published

Nguyen My Thong · AI Business Operations
github.com/iknizzz1807/the-estimator · the-estimator-xqzc.onrender.com